Prime Minister's central (and oft-repeated) message that economic growth is his faith, the Constitution is his holy book and Parliament is his temple.

Just as investors tend not to come to war zones—which is why peace on our borders is in our national interest—so too do investors prefer to risk their capital in harmonious societies that are focused on the future rather than divided by the past. The BJP and its Government should heed one simple dictum: leave religion to the personal space and preference of every Indian. Let us have no national holy book, just as our constitution forbids us from having a national religion. Our country was once divided over religion; let us not now promote a partition in the Indian soul that will be as bad as the partition we have already endured on Indian soil. Let us not awake demons that seven decades of secular Indian democracy have put to rest after the tragic horrors of 1947.

It is time to let sleeping dogmas lie.

NARROW-MINDED BIGOTRY

Hindutva takes a dully static view of India's cultural tradition, ignoring its capacity to react to and absorb foreign influences, and negating its inherent dynamism. In the name of this limited and narrow view of Hindu culture, and in addition to its threats to books, Hindutva activists have assaulted a film-maker for allegedly planning to shoot a love-scene between a Rajput princess and a Muslim conqueror (of which more later); vandalised exhibitions of M. F. Husain's paintings because he had depicted Hindu goddesses in the nude; disrupted the shooting of the Indo-Canadian Deepa Mehta's film on Benares widows for insulting an age-old Hindu practice; denigrated the Malayalam writer Kamala Das for her conversion to Islam as Kamala Suraiya; banned A. K. Ramanujam's classic text on the hundreds of versions of the *Ramayana* from the syllabus of Delhi University; and trashed a SAHMAT exhibition on the Ayodhya dispute. The politicisation of culture is truly complete under India's Hindutva government.

Of these, the assault on M. F. Husain and his works was typical of Hindutva intolerance. In 1996 a mob destroyed several paintings of the artist at an exhibition in Ahmedabad, outraged that a Muslim artist had